

dumping that trusted handset. There is a simple (well, almost) and easy (well, almost again) way to change the firmware on your Android phone and have a close-to-new phone whenever you like. Sounds interesting? Yeah, we know! Which is why we have decided to dedicate an entire Fast Track just to the subject of Custom ROMs.

Note: Anyone with a basic knowledge of anything technological will tell you that ROM stands for Read Only Memory. As the name suggests, ROMs will be read-only and cannot be modified. So the ideal term to use here would be 'firmware'. But that is not relevant to the end-user. Which is why the more commonly used term 'ROM' is what you will see used throughout.

What is a custom ROM?

Let's start at the very beginning. Android is an open source platform. And it is for this very reason that most developers are attracted to this OS. So every version of the Android OS that is available on the market can also be customised according to the will and skill set of the developer working on it. Keep this in mind while reading through the rest of this Fast Track.

When you unbox a brand new Android-run phone, it comes with a stock ROM - which is the version of the OS that the handset company chose for the model you have purchased. So any preloaded apps or services on there have been chosen by the handset manufacturer. A custom ROM, on the other hand, is an absolutely standalone version of the OS in which everything from the apps, services and even the kernel are customised in some way or the other. For the uninitiated, when it comes to OS talk, a kernel is the central part of the OS. It is what controls a number of functions, notably the memory and the CPU time. So basically, if you backtrack, every device has a custom ROM already in place. Here, the custom ROM is developed by the manufacturer. So every device has a slightly different ROM based on the same Android version like Oreo, Nougat, Marshmallow etc. But every device has its own set of peculiarities with regards to



Developing your own custom ROM is like signing your signature on your phone- digitally. You can add tweaks, change styles, boot animations and even add in your own themes